EL NIÑO ACTION BRIEFING · 10 OCTOBER 2026

Port Moresby, Papua New Guinea

El Niño is already here. Port Moresby is the driest place in New Guinea, its one water dam is under strain, and water was rationed across four zones in August. In a dry spell, whether someone dies depends less on how much water there is than on how far they are from rehydration salts and a clinic. In 2009–11, cholera killed about 1 in 1,000 people infected in the capital and nearly 9 in 100 in Western Province. The single most important step is to put rehydration points, water treatment, and lidded containers inside the settlements now, through the one organisation with a proven record of delivering there: PNG Red Cross.

IMPACT REGION	EXCESS HEAT DEATHS	WINDOW	DOMINANT HAZARD
National Capital District, PNG (inferred)	None published for Papua New Guinea	n/a here; global 6-month figure 239,000 ± 11,000	Dry-season drought (June–November) with water rationing that reaches the settlements last, diarrhoea and cholera risk, interrupted TB treatment, and grass fires

12/12 recommendations checked. 0 confirmed outright, 10 corrected, 1 unverified (a price cap on water trucks), and 1 contraindicated (using the World Bank water project's

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY — AT A GLANCE



9.44°S 147.18°E, Papua New Guinea · Natural Earth

- **The risk.** Dry-season drought with rationing that reaches settlements last drives diarrhoea and cholera; in 2009–11 cholera killed over 500 nationally, at 0.1% fatality in the NCD against 8.8% where treatment was far.
- **First action.** Now, PNG Red Cross and the NCD Provincial Health Authority put rehydration points, water treatment, and lidded containers in the settlements, with stool testing to trigger cholera vaccination.*
- **The money.** $511k floor, $1.09M target, $2.42M ceiling; the top placement is ~$400k to PNG Red Cross for rehydration points, water treatment, and lidded containers.
- **Do not.** Do not tell people to store water without lids or demolish settlements now: open containers breed dengue, and evictions push families into waterless settlements as disease risk peaks.*

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* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

emergency component, which closed in April 2026). A second financing route, building a new Red Cross anticipatory protocol for this event, is also flagged as closed. Exposure figure: Climate Impact Lab, September 2026, pre-peer-review, heat only. It publishes no figure for Papua New Guinea, and this event's main hazard here is drought, not heat, so no number is borrowed. **The funding target fell 39% in verification**, from $1.8M to $1.09M, because the per-person cost had been taken from rural food relief, not urban cholera preparedness. The floor rose, because the capital's population is about twice what was assumed. Nearly every lens and verifier exhausted its web-search budget, and ReliefWeb and the Bureau of Meteorology returned errors.

Where this is, and the resolution. The request named the city, not a district or settlement, so **these actions are generic at city level**. Port Moresby is the National Capital District (NCD), with three electorates: Moresby North-East, North-West, and South. The 2024 census counts **756,754** people in the NCD (citypopulation.de, citing the PNG National Statistical Office), against 364,125 in 2011; that doubling should be confirmed against the Office's own release. Over half of residents live in informal settlements or urban villages, among them 8-Mile, 9-Mile, Morata, Saraga, Kaugere, Bush Waitara, Gerehu, and the Motu-Koitabu stilt villages of Hanuabada. Many settlement households take water from shared meters or self-built connections that no rationing notice reaches. A settlement-level briefing would change the owners and the order of these actions.

What the forecast and the record say. NOAA's Oceanic Niño Index for July–September 2026 is about +2.2, already above where the 1972 and 2023 events peaked and on the track of 1997. Port Moresby averages about 899 mm of rain a year, with a June–November dry season, so El Niño deepens a drought the city has every year. The government told the country in June 2026 to prepare for a prolonged dry season, and in August officials said El Niño was “already straining the Sirinumu catchment.” One report says the city has been declared in drought; its source could not be reached.

WHAT THIS CITY SHOULD DO RANKED

Actions are ranked by expected lives saved per unit of effort. Because the dry season is already under way, “before the peak” here means now.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

The backing lenses are shown on each action, and the RACI chart below assigns each one.

1. Now, put rehydration points, oral rehydration salts and zinc, household water treatment, and lidded containers inside the settlements, and set Port Moresby General Hospital's stool testing to trigger cholera vaccination on the first confirmed case*

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | PUBLIC HEALTH · EMERGENCY MGR · PHILANTHROPIST · HISTORIAN · SKEPTIC · FRONTLINE | INVENTORY: NOT QUERIED

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
PNG Red Cross Society with the NCD Provincial Health Authority; Port Moresby General Hospital for surveillance; National Department of Health and WHO for a vaccine request	Now; rehydration points open within weeks	~$400k through PNG Red Cross (see funding)	Deaths from diarrhoea and cholera when rationing pushes households onto stored and vendor water

Papua New Guinea's 2009–11 cholera epidemic caused more than 15,500 cases and over 500 deaths. The case fatality rate was 0.1% in the NCD and 8.8% in Western Province (Horwood & Greenhill, *WPSAR* 2012). The difference was distance to treatment. Oral rehydration salts may prevent 93% of diarrhoea deaths (Munos, Walker & Black, *Int J Epidemiol* 2010). Household treatment cuts diarrhoea episodes: filters by about half (RR 0.48) and flocculant-disinfectant sachets by about a third (RR 0.69), both moderate certainty; chlorination alone by about a quarter (RR 0.77, low certainty) (Clasen et al., Cochrane 2015). Give lids and mesh with every container, because rationing tells people to store water in “containers and buckets,” and open containers breed dengue mosquitoes. Reactive oral cholera vaccination is about 75% effective (Schwerdtle et al. 2018).

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

Corrections: the Cochrane effects are on diarrhoea episodes, not deaths. GiveWell's 6–11% reduction in under-five deaths applies to in-line chlorination and dispensers, not sachets, and GiveWell calls it very uncertain. No record was found of Papua New Guinea ever running a cholera vaccination campaign, and how fast it could draw on the international emergency stockpile was not verified. No cholera reports from 2024–26 were found, which is not the same as confirmed absence. The dengue evidence for container lids comes from Queensland and was not re-checked.

2. PNG Red Cross should request an imminent-crisis DREF now, rather than waiting for cases

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | ECONOMIST · PHILANTHROPIST | INVENTORY: NOT QUERIED

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
PNG Red Cross Society; the IFRC Disaster Response Emergency Fund (DREF) is the payer	**October**	**Paid by the DREF; recent PNG DREFs ran CHF 80k–360k**	**Money arriving only after the outbreak, as it always has here**

Nothing is pre-arranged for Papua New Guinea. IFRC's GO platform lists 26 PNG appeals and none is an anticipatory protocol. Every El Niño drought payment to the country has come after the harm: the IFRC appeal of 1997 (CHF 570,000 for 160,000 people), the World Bank's $5M Emergency El Niño Drought Response approved in April 1998, and the 2015 drought DREF (CHF 150,669 for 15,000 people, opened in September). There is no 2026 drought or El Niño DREF for the country. PNG Red Cross has run 13 DREFs since 2006, including a cholera operation in 2009 (CHF 359,058 for 300,000 people) and a cyclone operation that runs to 31 October 2026.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

Corrections: a *simplified Early Action Protocol* cannot be used for an event already under way, because it must be approved before its trigger is reached; it is a project for 2027 (see *Do not do this*). The imminent-crisis DREF's ceiling and procedure were not verified. Papua New Guinea holds no sovereign cover with the Pacific Catastrophe Risk Insurance Company; its only policy there is PNG DataCo's earthquake cover for a subsea cable. Tonga holds drought cover and received payouts in 2026, so joining for the 2027 season is a real option.

3. Get rationing notices and water to the households that have no meter: read them out in church and at ward meetings in Tok Pisin and Hiri Motu, truck water on a published, independently monitored roster, and stop cutting off whole communities over one shared bill during the drought

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | FRONTLINE · SKEPTIC · EMERGENCY MGR · HISTORIAN | INVENTORY: NOT QUERIED

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
Water PNG and the NCD Commission; churches and ward councillors relay; church or NGO monitors oversee the truck roster	Now, for every rationing cycle	Relay is volunteer time; trucking not costed	Settlements finding out about rationing when the tap runs dry, and relief following political loyalty instead of need

The 14 August 2026 rationing notice went out through the media and Water PNG's website and did not mention settlements; it told residents to store water in buckets, and only two hospitals with a dedicated connection were exempt. In 2016, water to many communities came through one shared meter, and when some households could not pay their share, the whole community was cut off. In the 2015–16 drought, relief was paid from MP-controlled district funds (up to K2m per district), and a provincial officer said “supply goes to the stronghold”; that was rural, but the same channels exist in the city. The frontline lens put it plainly: if the pastor doesn't read it out on Sunday, the settlement finds out when the tap runs dry. On 17 September 2026, Australian aid trucked 37,000 litres into one Port Moresby school, citing rationing and El Niño; there is no settlement program.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

Corrections: the relay, the monitored roster, and the drought waiver are proposals with no PNG precedent found. The “over half” figure covers informal settlements *and* urban villages. A K8.35M water project for the Motu-Koitabu villages started around 31 August 2026 but will not help this dry season. A price cap on water-truck vendors was proposed but is unverified: no documented price spikes were found, and price control in Papua New Guinea normally sits with the ICCC, not the NCD Commission.

4. Agree in writing the Sirinumu Dam levels at which hydro generation is cut to protect drinking water, with gas and other hydro covering each step, and secure court-ordered access to the dam and the Rouna pipeline before the next blockade

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | EMERGENCY MGR · HISTORIAN | INVENTORY: NOT QUERIED

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
Water PNG and PNG Power; the State for landowner access orders	31 Oct	Near zero, plus fuel for gas-fired cover	The 1997 trade-off, made on the spot, between the city's water and its power

Sirinumu is the only dam supplying the city. In 1997 its hydro was forced to stop to conserve drinking water, causing serious power failures (Allen & Bourke, ANU 2009). In December 2015 it fell to about 35% and the utility rationed some zones six hours on, six hours off. Landowners have closed the dam (2015, 2017, 2019), and generation stops about six hours after a closure. In August 2026 a blockade on the 65-year-old Rouna 1/3 pipeline was cleared by a National Court interim order, not a settlement, and the leak was losing about 10 million litres a day.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

Corrections: the grid no longer depends mainly on Sirinumu. Dirio gas (45 MW, since 2021), NiuPower gas (58 MW, 2020), and Edevu hydro (about 50 MW, late 2023) now feed it, though Edevu is also rain-fed and gas supply may be affected by the 2026 regional fuel crisis. Rouna's installed capacity is given as 89 MW and as 66.2 MW in different sources. The 2017 closure was over an unbuilt road, not compensation. A full compensation settlement before the peak is unrealistic; a court order or escrow is the feasible version. No current dam level and no second water source were found.

5. Keep TB and drug-resistant TB patients on treatment through rationing and displacement: several months of drugs at a time, tracing of patients who move, and all-oral regimens where supply allows*

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | PUBLIC HEALTH | INVENTORY: NOT QUERIED

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
National TB Program with Port Moresby General Hospital and the NCD Provincial Health Authority	Now	Within existing program	Lost treatment, deaths, and spread of drug-resistant TB

Loss to follow-up is already high at Port Moresby General Hospital: 22% of drug-resistant TB patients were lost before starting treatment (2018–22) and 24% during it (2014–19). Loss was 27% on injectable regimens against 12% on all-oral ones (*Public Health Action* 2024). At one Port Moresby clinic, 30.5% of people tested for TB were positive.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

Corrections: the link between drought and TB outcomes is extrapolated; the closest study (Brazilian Amazon, 2023–24 drought) found more TB notifications but interrupted treatment only for HIV. The all-oral comparison is observational and small. All-oral regimens are WHO policy already, so this is a program fix that drought makes more urgent, not an El Niño measure in its own right. Bedaquiline supply was not verified.

6. Commission a rapid food-and-water assessment of the NCD settlements now, and watch rice and flour prices with the importers

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | HISTORIAN · SKEPTIC | INVENTORY: NOT QUERIED

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
National Disaster Centre with the NCD Commission; university and donor partners for method	November	Not costed	Relief going out before anyone knows who needs it, as in 1997

In 1997, more than K1M was sent to MPs pro rata by population before any assessment; the national assessment that followed (ANU and AusAID) found 260,000 people eating famine foods and 980,000 more eating poor food in reduced amounts by December. In towns, the burden came through imported-food prices after the kina fell from US$0.72 to US$0.48, and through relatives arriving from drought areas. In 2015–16 about 770,000 people were in very food-scarce areas and rice sales rose 35–40%.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

Corrections: the 1997 assessments were national and rural; there is no settlement-level model to copy, so the method must be adapted. Rice Industries did not raise rice prices in 1997 despite the kina's fall. A claimed remittance figure and a “K30M against K600M” comparison for 2015 could not be verified and are not used.

7. Ask the NCD Governor, Police, and Lands to pause executing existing eviction orders until the dry season breaks

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED · LOW FEASIBILITY | SKEPTIC · FRONTLINE | INVENTORY: NOT QUERIED

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
NCD Governor and Commission; Royal PNG Constabulary; Department of Lands; courts where settlers have filed	Now	None	Displaced households crowding into other settlements without water, just as disease risk peaks

The Two-Mile Hill eviction (January–February 2026) destroyed at least 150 dwellings on 8.8 hectares and left about 1,200 people homeless, most of whom moved into other crowded settlements. On 30 January 2026 police said orders for Garden Hills, Badili, 4-Mile Works, 6-Mile, and 8-Mile were ready, some delayed by settlers' court actions.

No Papua New Guinea precedent for a drought or disaster eviction pause was found. The evictions are framed by the Governor and the Acting Prime Minister as anti-crime measures, and two people were killed, so the political barrier is high.

8. Name the people who will step in when a drought misfortune turns into a sorcery accusation: pastors, ward councillors, and health workers, with routes to police, clinics, and safe houses

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | FRONTLINE · SKEPTIC | INVENTORY: NOT QUERIED

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
Churches and ward leaders, under the revised Sorcery Accusation Related Violence National Action Plan	Now	Volunteer time	Violence against people blamed for sickness, deaths, or crop failure

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

An ANU Devpolicy analysis (Moloney, Forsyth & Mason, 29 September 2026) asks whether El Niño is a risk factor for sorcery-accusation violence. In its 2016–20 data from four provinces, about 90% of cases were triggered by sickness or death, which drought and disease increase.

Corrections: all the evidence is rural; there is none for the NCD, and the authors say “we actually don't know as yet.” The link is plausible, not shown.

9. Clear grass 3–5 metres around settlement homes and power poles, and enforce the ban on burning dried grass *

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | EMERGENCY MGR | INVENTORY: NOT QUERIED

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
PNG Fire Service with ward councillors and youth groups	Now	Volunteer time	Grass fires reaching homes and power lines on the dry hills

The Fire Service warned residents in July 2025, after a bushfire at Dabunari damaged a high-voltage pole, and again on 18 August 2026; RNZ photographed a bushfire near homes at Hohola on 24 August 2026.

No documented settlement burn-over and no NCD Commission firebreak program were found, so this is the Fire Service's own advice, not a new program.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

WHO DOES WHAT

RACI CHART

R = Responsible (does the work) · **A** = Accountable (one per action; signs off and answers for it) · **C** = Consulted (asked before) · **I** = Informed (told after). Built from the owners named in the verified actions. No one here has been contacted or has agreed to a role; every row is a proposal.

Action	PNG Red Cross	NCD Health Authority	NDoH / WHO	Port Moresby General	Water PNG	PNG Power	NCD Commission	National Disaster Centre	Police / Lands	Churches / ward leaders	PNG Fire Service
1. Rehydration points, water treatment, lids; cholera trigger	**A/R**	**R**	**C**	**R**	**C**		**I**	**I**		**R**	
2. Imminent-crisis DREF request	**A/R**	**C**	**C**				**I**	**C**			
3. Notices and water to unmetered households	**C**				**A/R**		**R**	**C**		**R**	
4. Dam curtailment rule; access orders					**A/R**	**R**	**C**	**C**	**C**		
5. TB treatment continuity	**C**	**R**	**A/R**	**R**						**R**	
6. Settlement food-and-water assessment	**R**	**C**			**C**		**R**	**A/R**		**C**	
7. Pause eviction orders							**A/R**	**C**	**R**	**C**	
8. Intervenors for sorcery accusations	**C**	**R**					**C**		**R**	**A/R**	
9. Grass clearance; burning ban						**C**	**C**			**R**	**A/R**

What the chart shows. **PNG Red Cross carries the top two rows**, which concentrates the response in the one partner with a verified delivery record, and also concentrates the risk: its capacity to absorb money before the peak is about $0.4–0.5M. **Churches and ward leaders appear in six of nine rows**; they are the delivery channel for the households no official notice reaches, and no one has funded or asked them.

WHERE MONEY DOES THE MOST

FUNDING

The Philanthropist lens, reconciled against the ranked actions and verified. Amounts are in US dollars. Placements are ranked by expected lives saved per dollar, using Papua New Guinea's own epidemic-response costs as the anchor. The envelope is bounded by what partners in the NCD can spend, which is the tighter limit.

FLOOR	TARGET	CEILING	LARGEST UNCERTAINTY
$511k	**$1.09M**	**$2.42M**	**Absorptive capacity: no partner other than PNG Red Cross has a verified NCD delivery record**

At-risk population = 45% (an *assumed* settlement share; no published figure was found) × 756,754 = 340,539. **Floor:** 340,539 × $1.50 = **$511k**, using the 2009 cholera DREF's CHF 1.20 per person at about $1.25 per franc. **Target:** 340,539 × $3.20 = **$1.09M**, using the 2018 polio DREF's CHF 2.57 per person, the top of PNG's epidemic-response range. **Ceiling:** 756,754 × $3.20 = **$2.42M**. **The target fell 39% in**

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

verification, from $1.8M: the lens had applied $10 a person from the 2015 *rural drought food relief* DREF, which does not transfer to urban cholera preparedness. The exchange rate and the 45% share are unverified. The largest appeal ever funded in Papua New Guinea was CHF 812,774 (1997), so anything above about $0.5M needs channels beyond PNG Red Cross, and none was verified.

RECIPIENT	USE	AMOUNT	MECHANISM	BASIS	VERDICT
PNG Red Cross Society (13 DREFs since 2006; 2009 cholera operation for 300,000 people)	Action 1: rehydration points, water treatment, lidded containers, hygiene promotion	~$400k	Direct grant, or top-up to an imminent-crisis DREF	PNG epidemic DREFs ran CHF 1.20–2.57 per person. Its 2026 cyclone DREF (CHF 250k, 5,000 people) is still open, so current delivery at scale is unproven	PARTIALLY CONFIRMED
NCD Provincial Health Authority or church health networks	Household water treatment at scale	Remainder of target, conditional	Direct grant, only after a delivery record is shown	No unit cost and no NCD delivery record were found	UNVERIFIED
National Department of Health / WHO	Cholera surveillance and vaccine readiness	Not costed	Gated on a stockpile request	Reactive vaccination is ~75% effective; PNG has no campaign record	GATED
Water trucking and tanks	Action 3, only where piped supply has failed	Last call on funds	Per delivery, on a monitored roster	High cost per life saved	LAST

The funder's one thing: there has been no Red Cross drought appeal for Papua New Guinea since 2015, and none for the 2023–24 El Niño. The best dollar is probably not water. It is cash to the one partner that has shown it can move, aimed at a cholera-ready settlement response and released before the first case. Before money goes anywhere else, ask for that agency's NCD delivery record. No verifier could find one.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

DO NOT DO THIS — CONTRAINDICATED

Advice that circulates for this hazard and would cost lives, money, or trust here.

Plan on the World Bank water project's emergency component, or on building a new anticipatory protocol, to fund this winter's response

CONTRAINDICATED

One lens proposed drawing on the contingent emergency component of the World Bank's Water Supply and Sanitation Development Project (P155087, $70M). That component was funded at $0, the project's closing date was extended to 30 April 2026 with no later extension disclosed, and it served provincial towns, not the NCD. A simplified Early Action Protocol with IFRC has to be approved before its trigger is reached, so it cannot be used for a drought already under way. Time spent on either is time not spent on the DREF request that is actually open.

Instead: an imminent-crisis DREF now (action 2). For 2027, build the protocol and seek Pacific catastrophe-insurance drought cover. The live World Bank emergency component is in the Resilient Transport project (P166991), which is not a water channel.

Send water or food relief through MPs and District Development Authorities

DO NOT DO

In 1997, relief money went to MPs pro rata before any assessment. In 2015–16, districts were told to use their MP-controlled development funds, and fieldwork found that “supply goes to the stronghold” and “the most needy will not necessarily be the most aided.” Those findings are rural, but the channels are the same in the capital.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

Instead: a published, needs-based roster by ward and settlement, with church or NGO monitors (action 3).

Tell people to "store water" without giving them a lid, or demolish settlements during the drought *

DO NOT DO

Uncovered containers breed dengue mosquitoes, and stored water is how diarrhoeal disease spreads in rationing. Demolitions push families into other settlements that already lack water, at the moment disease risk is highest; the 1,200 people displaced from Two-Mile Hill this year moved further in, not out.

Instead: lids and mesh with every container message (action 1), and a pause on eviction orders until the rains (action 7).

WHAT HAS HAPPENED HERE BEFORE — THE RECORD

YEAR	EVENT	TOLL	WHAT CHANGED AFTER
1972–73, 1982–83	Strong El Niños (ONI peaks 1.8, 2.1)	Not found for Port Moresby	—
1997–98	Very strong El Niño (ONI 2.4); national drought and frosts	1.24M eating famine or reduced food by Dec 1997; Sirinumu hydro stopped, serious city power failures; kina fell a third	IFRC appeal CHF 570,000; World Bank $5M (1998); Australia A$30M. ANU's June warning went unanswered until September
2009–11	Cholera epidemic, PNG's first recorded	15,500+ cases, 500+ deaths; NCD fatality rate 0.1%, Western Province 8.8%	IFRC cholera DREF, 300,000 people
2015–16	Very strong El Niño (ONI 2.6)	Sirinumu at 35%; six-hours-on, six-off rationing; ~770,000 in food-scarce areas nationally	K2m per district from MP-controlled funds; relief politicised
2017, 2019	Landowner closures of Sirinumu	Power stops ~6 hours after a closure	Keys recovered by police (2017)

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

YEAR	EVENT	TOLL	WHAT CHANGED AFTER
2020–23	New generation: NiuPower gas, Dirio gas, Edevu hydro	—	Grid less dependent on Sirinumu
Jan–Feb 2026	Two-Mile Hill eviction	150+ dwellings destroyed; ~1,200 homeless; two killed	Orders ready for five more settlements
Jun–Sep 2026	Strong El Niño onset (ONI ~2.2)	Prolonged dry-season warning (June); four-zone rationing and pipeline blockade cleared by court (August); bushfire at Hohola; water trucked to a school (September)	—

The recurrence nobody has noticed: in June 1997, ANU wrote to the head of Papua New Guinea's emergency service warning that the Southern Oscillation Index had made its steepest fall in fifty years. No one acknowledged the letter, and the response began only after a *Sydney Morning Herald* front page on 15 September. In 2026, the index of El Niño strength was already above 2 by September, and the country still has no pre-arranged money. The forecast arriving early has never been the problem here. Acting on it has.

WHERE THE EXPERTS DISAGREE — UNRESOLVED

- **Truck water to the settlements** (Emergency mgr) versus **trucking is the most expensive way to save a life; fund rehydration first** (Philanthropist, Public health). Resolved as: rehydration first (action 1), trucking only where piped supply has failed and on a monitored roster.
- **“The dam supplies more than half the city's power”** (Emergency mgr, Historian) versus **two gas plants and a new hydro station since 2020** (verification). Resolved: the water–power trade-off is smaller than in 1997, but Edevu is also rain-fed and gas supply faces a regional fuel crisis.
- **The size of the city.** The lenses assumed about 400,000 people; the 2024 census figure found is 756,754. The jump from 364,125 in 2011 should be checked with the National Statistical Office, because every per-person figure in this briefing scales with it.
- **Drought as a trigger for sorcery-accusation violence in the city** (Frontline, Skeptic) versus **only rural evidence** (verification). Kept as a low-cost precaution.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

WHAT NOBODY COVERED — BLIND SPOT

Heat, and the first rains. Climate Impact Lab's estimate is about heat, and Port Moresby is hot in the late dry season, yet no lens found any heat-health data for the city, and none looked at who is most exposed: market vendors, outdoor workers, and older people in iron-roofed settlement houses. And no lens examined what happens when the drought ends. After a long dry spell, the first heavy rains flush accumulated waste into the water people collect, and run off hard ground; that is a classic moment for diarrhoea outbreaks and flash floods. Both deserve a check with the NCD Health Authority before December.

HOW TO READ THIS — METHOD

The panel is author-built. Seven simulated expert lenses were used to generate these recommendations. Where they agree, that is a strong hypothesis, not a consensus of the field. Every recommendation was then independently checked for evidence, transferability to this location, and feasibility before the peak; the verdict tags carry the result.

Mortality figures are resolved at Climate Impact Lab impact-region scale. The El Niño projection covers *heat only*; drought, water-borne disease, fire, and food insecurity are additional to it and are carried here by the historical record rather than by a published number.

HOW THIS BRIEFING WAS PRODUCED — METHODOLOGY

- **Scope.** The request named “Port Moresby, Papua New Guinea”, a city. It was run at city level without asking for a district, and the report says so: actions are generic at that resolution. Climate Impact Lab impact region, as the report records it: National Capital District, PNG, *inferred* rather than resolved on the Impact Map.
- **Exposure.** Climate Impact Lab, *451,000 at Risk* (September 2026, pre-peer-review): ECMWF SEAS5 seasonal forecasts (51-member ensemble) applied to temperature–mortality relationships across 24,378 regions, against a 1996–2025 baseline, for June 2026 – February 2027. It covers heat only. Its published breakdown names Indonesia and Southeast Asia but not Papua New Guinea, and no figure is scaled to the NCD.
- **Expert panel.** Seven simulated expert lenses (emergency manager, public health scientist, frontline responder, skeptic, economist, historian, and philanthropist) researched the city independently and in parallel, from web sources, to a fixed brief.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

- **Reconciliation.** Duplicate actions were merged and backing lenses recorded. Convergence was tested for shared bias: six lenses converged on water and disease, and their evidence includes Papua New Guinea's own 2009–11 cholera data, so it stands; the Cochrane and GiveWell effects come from other countries and are labelled. Contradictions were kept. Actions were ranked and reconciled against the funding placements.
- **Verification.** Six verifier agents checked 12 recommendations, the historical record, the financial instruments, and the funding placements. Verifiers queried the IFRC GO appeals API, the World Bank projects API and project documents, the NOAA CPC ONI table, Europe PMC and PubMed, and fetched the ANU Press chapter on 1997–98 directly. The author fetched the census figure. The envelope was re-summed.
- **Verdicts.** *Confirmed*: evidence, transferability, and feasibility all hold. *Partially confirmed*: holds after the corrections shown. *Unverified*: could not be checked to a primary source. *Contraindicated*: would do harm or waste the window here.
- **Adaptation Inventory.** Not queried in this run; the page loads its listings by JavaScript and earlier verifiers could not query it. Every action is tagged “not queried”, which is not the same as “no precedent”.
- **Health wording.** Passages where a wording error could hurt someone (oral rehydration salts, zinc, and water treatment, water storage, TB treatment, and grass fires) are marked "* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing." They were checked against published sources, not by a health professional. They are suggestions, not medical advice, and anyone passing them on should confirm them with a doctor, pharmacist, nurse, or community health worker first. The marker was added on 2 November 2026.
- **Rules.** No cost is derived by dividing a published total, and no local figure is invented; per-person costs are Papua New Guinea's own past DREF budgets, and the settlement share and exchange rate are labelled assumptions.
- **Limits.** Nearly every lens and verifier exhausted its web-search budget. ReliefWeb, the Bureau of Meteorology, DFAT, the Bank of PNG, and several RNZ pages returned errors, so the drought declaration, current dam level, CERF and DFAT funding for 2026, current cholera status, and the exchange rate are unverified. The census figure comes from a secondary site. The panel and verifiers are AI research agents working from English-language web sources; no one in Port Moresby was interviewed, and Tok Pisin and Hiri Motu sources were not searched.

References · verified by Phase 5 unless marked. NOAA CPC ONI v6 (verified) · NOAA CPC ENSO discussion, 8 Oct 2026 (verified) · City Population, NCD census counts (secondary; queried 10 Oct 2026) · Allen & Bourke 2009, the 1997–98 drought (ANU Press) (corrected) · Devpolicy, 2015–16 drought impact (verified) · Devpolicy, politicising drought relief (verified) · Devpolicy, August 2026 aid news (verified; drought declaration source unreachable) · Horwood & Greenhill 2012, PNG cholera (verified) · Munos, Walker & Black 2010, ORS and diarrhoea deaths (verified) · Clasen et al. 2015, Cochrane, household water treatment (corrected) · GiveWell, water quality interventions (corrected) · MDR-TB loss to follow-up, PMGH (2024) (verified) · TB positivity, Port Moresby clinic (verified) · Drought and TB, Brazilian Amazon (2026) (verified) · The National, August 2026

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

rationing (verified) · NBC PNG, rationing and pipeline repairs (verified) · NBC PNG, court order on pipeline blockade (verified) · The National, water trucked to a school (verified) · Devpolicy, communal meters (corrected) · The National, Motu-Koitabu water project (corrected) · Sirinumu Dam (secondary) · Dirio gas plant (verified) · Islands Business, Edevu hydro (verified) · Devpolicy, Two-Mile Hill eviction (verified) · NBC PNG, planned evictions (verified) · NBC PNG, Governor on Two-Mile eviction (verified) · Devpolicy, El Niño and sorcery-accusation violence (verified; rural evidence) · The National, fire warning 2025 (verified) · The National, fire chief's warning 2026 (verified) · IFRC GO, PNG appeals (queried) · World Bank P055446, 1998 El Niño drought response (verified) · World Bank P155087 restructuring paper (verified) · PCRIC, PNG DataCo policy (verified) · Islands Business, PCRIC drought cover (secondary) · Australian Humanitarian Partnership, El Niño preparedness 2023–24 (verified)
Exposure data · Climate Impact Lab, 451,000 at Risk · Impact Map · Adaptation Inventory
Generated 10 October 2026 for Port Moresby, Papua New Guinea. El Niño Ready is volunteer-run and is not affiliated with Climate Week NYC, The Climate Group, or Columbia University.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.